

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 2

Resisting with Joy ~ Humility

19 April 2026



Photo by Tenzin Choejor

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on BEACH SPRING and NETTLETON

Beethoven-Improvisation (Christoph Bull)

Golden (24/Ejæ/Ido/Park/Sonneblick)

Prelude and Fugue in G Major, BWV 541 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

This Is The Day (Gunther Martin Götsche)

Nothing Compares 2 Prince (arr. C. Bull)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Emily Kang & Lulu Gregoropoulos

How beautiful are those lit from within by joy.
Their glow warms all who meet their gaze,
whose eyes settle upon their gentle, healing light.

In a crowd, we seek them out.
On a street, we feel a surge of delight
as we pass them by, open to their magic.

If we could but will ourselves such blessing!
How holy would become our lives,
how filled with beauty and with peace!
Infused with joy,
the world would be transformed
and we its transformation.

Even in these days of uncertainty it is possible...
if we open ourselves
beyond the careful, pre-set ways
that we have learned to be.

*Beginning on this day,
may we be touched by the wonder of joy,
may we be infused with its blessing,
and may we, in turn,
release it to the world around us.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

In the Midst of All Our Living

NETTLETON

In the midst of every blessing, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May our words be filled with gratitude; may our glad hearts humble be.
As a holder of a blessing, may we share it gratefully.

In the midst of every trial, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of comfort, ever flowing, call for songs of highest praise.
May we find the strength within us; may we sense it everywhere.
As we face what must be handled, may we find truth we can share.

In the midst of all our living, may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we seek and find encouragement; may our choices worthy be.
As we journey on together, may we know integrity.

-Lyrics by Scott Kearns, 2008, inspired by Robert Robinson, 1758

Prayer of Awareness

Claire Kelly

Holy One,
as we live in these days spun from uncertainty,
we greet this Eastertide morning.
Promises of wonder and resignation, delight and sorrow,
hope and fear, joy and sadness,
lie waiting for us to navigate, no matter what comes.
We long to recreate with you a world that
welcomes strangers and makes them siblings.

Into these moments between
pain and possibility,
may we weave a tapestry of life;
and as we cherish the gifts it has to offer,
might the beauty, truth, and goodness
that still reside within us all
be illumined with new meaning for each of us.

*As those born into love,
yet ever seeking it,
we offer ourselves to
your Spirit of Life.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

"Golden" from KPop Demon Hunters
Cathedral Choir & Commonwealth

EJAE, MARK SONNENBLICK, 24, IDO,
AND TEDDY

***The Lord's Prayer**

Juniper Fayazova

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,*

*and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

A deep and wondrous Holiness abides
both in the farthest reaches of the oceans,
and here in the midst of our hearts and minds.

May we feel its presence in this day of celebration.
May we share the excitement of those who today,
embark upon this journey of discovery and awe.

And as we watch, and sing, and pray,
may we feel the excitement of our own journey;
the thrill of discovery,
the joy of the open road,
the hope that once called us forth
from familiar places.

On this day, may all this and so much more be in our midst,
and may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Confirming the Class of 2026

*Mignon "Lulu" Aleksandr Gregoropoulos
Garfield Morris Jr.
Juniper Mae Fayazova
Emily Yejin Kang
William Hojin Kang
Alizar I. Jmaya
Maximilian Adrian Sebastian Bull*

Claire Kelly & William Kang

Claire Kelly & Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Loving God,
we have gathered this morning
with our siblings,
desiring with all our hearts
to follow you
on this journey of life.

We are pastors, poets,
seekers, doubters,
some feeling whole,
and some fractured.
And yet, we are a magnificent,
hopeful community of diverse people,
people who all carry your image in our souls.

Help that image, O God, that is deeply planted
in our being, take root and grow
in the fullness of your presence.

Help us to abandon the assumptions
that our growth and the world's peace
are possible without you.

Humble us that we might journey with you,
listen to you, and learn from you.
Help us to unearth the gifts you have placed
in each of us.
Help us to trust the still, small voice that remembers
how deep your love is for each one of us.

And then, O God, teach us how to be faithful
in using all we have been given
as we hold the gift of this, your world -
and each other -
in reverence and humility.

This morning, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"The Great Unknown"
Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

STEVE GREGOROPOULOS

Sermon

Humility ~ Knowing How Much We Don't Know

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Alizar Jmaya & Max Bull

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Love Is Come Again"
Cathedral Choir

HENRY WHIPPLE

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Garfield Morris Jr. & Emily Kang

Ancient One,
in this Season of New Life,
may we remember all who have
brought your gifts to us.

We give thanks for those who cloak
themselves in humility
and always offer what we need most.

In these coming days, O God,
may we learn from them
and may we too, offer our gifts
to those who need us the most.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

In caring for one another,
may we be untiring.
In challenging one another,
may we be respectful.
In sheltering one another,
may we be strong.

In holding one another,
may we be tender.
In the expectations we have of one another,
may we be realistic.
In the songs we sing with one another,
may we seek harmony.
And in loving one another,
may we be all these things,
and more.

*As we seek to hold joy and humility with one another
in this sacred time, may God continue to use us to heal our world.*

May it be so.
*May it be so both now,
all in all the days to come!*

Choral Response

"Live A-Humble"
Cathedral Choir

PETER BAGLEY

*Hymn for the Journey *Lord, Whose Love Through Humble Service*

BEACH SPRING

Lord, whose love in humble service bore the weight of human need,
Who upon the cross, forsaken, worked your mercy's perfect deed:
We, your servants, bring the worship not of voice alone, but heart;
Consecrating to your purpose ev'ry gift which you impart.

Still your children wander homeless; still the hungry cry for bread;
Still the captives long for freedom; still in grief we mourn our dead.
As you, Lord, in deep compassion healed the sick and freed the soul,
By your Spirit send your power to our world to make it whole.

Called by worship to your service, forth in your dear name we go,
To the child, the youth, the aged, love in living deeds to show;
Hope and health, good will and comfort, counsel, aid and peace we give,
That your servants, Lord, are freed.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
This Is The Day - Reprise (Gunther Martin Göttsche)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"Humility feels like one of the more misunderstood virtues today. I think to many it feels like giving up our edge to create space for unknowing. This week's music reminds us of the worlds that await us when we release into our smallness. I love Bagley's setting of the spiritual "Live A-Humble." It bounces and sways as it reminds us that we can always take a step back from our need to project ourselves onto others. "Love Is Come Again" uses earth-centered metaphors set to the French carol tune we associate with "Sing We Now Of Christmas." There can be no more humbling recognition than when we measure ourselves against Mother Earth. We are always better for it as well. We open this week with "Golden" from "Kpop Demon Hunters" as a tribute to the confirmands who will lead the service today. It is also a reminder of a central theme in the film that humility leads to potential. The Cathedral Ringers premiere a new piece by our own Steve Gregoropoulos as well. Steve writes about his music that:

“All of my handbell pieces are expressly idiomatic in that they all deal with the physical act of ringing bells with two hands. “The Great Unknown” leans into this and also explores the idea unique to handbell and gamelan ensembles of each musician being responsible for a particular note as opposed to playing a melodic line or vertical sonority. The conductor plays one half of the choir which is a machine, and the other half is its own machine. Eventually the machines gain freedom and form into an organism on their own. Also my handbell pieces mostly deal with death and the world to come. It's a mystery reflected in the relationships of the players.”

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